FREE GUIDE · @DAILYHERBCHINESE

10 Chinese Herbs That Belong in Your Life

Ancient wisdom. Modern science. No mysticism required.

@dailyherbchinese

Chinese medicine has been cataloguing herbs for over 2,000 years. Most of what it discovered, modern pharmacology is only now confirming.

This guide covers **10 herbs you can actually use** — available at most Asian grocery stores, backed by research, and rooted in a system that treated the whole person long before that idea became a wellness trend.

No credentials required. Start with one. See what changes.

IN THIS GUIDE

01 Fresh Ginger
02 Goji Berries
03 Jujube Dates
04 Astragalus
05 Reishi
06 Chrysanthemum
07 Longan
08 Hawthorn
09 Schisandra
10 Lotus Seed

HERB 01 / 10

生姜

Shēng Jiāng · Fresh Ginger

The herb that warms the surface and rescues the stomach

Warm nature | Pungent | Lung · Spleen · Stomach

WHAT TCM USES IT FOR

In TCM, ginger is classically called **"the sage herb for vomiting."** It fights early colds by gently promoting sweating to push out pathogens, settles nausea by directing rebellious Stomach Qi downward, and warms the lungs. It also **detoxifies other potent herbs**, serving as a safety buffer in formulas.

THE THING MOST PEOPLE DON'T KNOW

> **Fresh and dried ginger are two entirely different medicines.** Fresh ginger (Shēng Jiāng) is warm. Dried ginger (Gān Jiāng) is **hot** — and acts on an additional organ, the Heart. The chemistry confirms this: drying transforms 6-gingerol into **6-shogaol**, a compound markedly more potent for anti-inflammatory activity. TCM recognized this 2,000 years before chemistry existed.

WHAT SCIENCE SAYS

Galanolactone in ginger acts as a **competitive antagonist at serotonin 5-HT3 receptors** — the same target as ondansetron (Zofran), a leading prescription anti-nausea drug. A trial of 576 cancer patients confirmed ginger significantly reduces chemotherapy-induced nausea.

HOW TO USE IT

- → Slice 3–5 thin coins into hot water, steep 10 min, add honey
- → Boil with two scallion whites and brown sugar for a cold remedy — drink hot, then bundle up
- → Add freely to soups, stir-fries, and congee

⚠ **Caution:** Avoid with warfarin or blood thinners. Stop supplements 2 weeks before surgery. Not for people who run hot or have acid reflux.

CLASSIC FORMULA

Guì Zhī Tāng (桂枝汤) — "Cinnamon Twig Decoction." The grandmother of hundreds of TCM formulas. Treats early-stage colds and harmonizes the body's defenses.

HERB 02 / 10

枸杞子

Gǒu Qǐ Zǐ · Goji Berry

The world's richest source of zeaxanthin

Neutral | Sweet | Liver · Kidney

WHAT TCM USES IT FOR

Goji nourishes the Liver and Kidneys, replenishing what TCM calls **Jing** — the deepest vital reserves. Its most celebrated function is **brightening the eyes**: the Liver "opens to the eyes," and when Liver Yin depletes from screen time, stress, or aging, vision suffers. Goji also tonifies Blood for fatigue and pale complexion.

THE THING MOST PEOPLE DON'T KNOW

> **Goji berries belong to the nightshade family** — alongside tomatoes, potatoes, and tobacco. People following nightshade-elimination diets for autoimmune protocols may need to avoid them. Also: despite being a Yin tonic, goji can **also strengthen Kidney Yang** when paired with warming herbs — making it a rare dual-action herb.

WHAT SCIENCE SAYS

Goji berries contain **31–56% zeaxanthin** of total carotenoids — the richest known natural dietary source. A clinical trial found that adults eating 28g of goji berries five times weekly for 90 days showed significantly increased macular pigment optical density, a protective biomarker against age-related macular degeneration. A supplement group did not.

HOW TO USE IT

- → Eat 10–30g raw daily like raisins
- → Steep 10–15 berries with chrysanthemum flowers for classic Chinese eye-health tea
- → Add to congee, chicken soup, oatmeal, or smoothies

→ Eat the berries after steeping — don't waste them

⚠ **Critical:** Multiple documented cases of dangerous bleeding in patients on warfarin. Interacts with statins, benzodiazepines, and calcium channel blockers. Avoid during colds or flu.

CLASSIC FORMULA

Qǐ Jú Dì Huáng Wán (杞菊地黄丸) — "Lycium, Chrysanthemum & Rehmannia Pill." The go-to OTC formula for blurred vision, dry eyes, dizziness from Liver-Kidney Yin deficiency.

HERB 03 / 10

大枣

Dà Zǎo · Red Jujube Date

The quiet "bass player" of Chinese medicine

Warm | Sweet | Spleen · Stomach · Heart

WHAT TCM USES IT FOR

Jujube strengthens the digestive system, nourishes Blood, and calms the mind for anxiety and restless sleep. Its most distinctive role is as a **formula harmonizer** — it moderates harsh herbs, protects the stomach from irritation, and improves absorption of other ingredients.

THE THING MOST PEOPLE DON'T KNOW

> Jujube appears in **more classical TCM formulas than almost any other herb** — not because of its own potency (it's quite mild), but because it makes every other herb work better. It's the bass player of Chinese medicine: rarely the star, but the formula collapses without it. Additionally, jujube contains **the highest concentration of cyclic adenosine monophosphate (cAMP) found in any of 180+ natural plants tested** — a critical molecule regulating cellular growth and immune response.

WHAT SCIENCE SAYS

Jujuboside A — the key sedative compound — works through **GABAergic modulation**, upregulating GABA and enhancing receptor expression. This is the same pathway as many

pharmaceutical sleep aids. Its saponins and triterpenoids exert anti-inflammatory activity through the NF-κB pathway.

HOW TO USE IT

→ Simmer 5–8 pitted dates in water 20 min with ginger slices for daily tonic tea

→ Add 6–8 dates to rice congee for a classic nourishing breakfast

→ Eat 3–5 whole dates as a mid-afternoon snack

→ Always remove pits — they are thought to create excess heat

⚠ **Caution:** Avoid with bloating or loose stools. High natural sugars require caution in diabetes. May interact with venlafaxine and medications metabolized by CYP1A2.

CLASSIC FORMULA

Gān Mài Dà Zǎo Tāng (甘麦大枣汤) — Just three pantry ingredients for emotional instability, unexplained crying, anxiety, and insomnia. 1,800 years old. Confirmed effective in clinical reviews for depression.

HERB 04 / 10

黄芪

Huáng Qí · Astragalus

The herb that activates the enzyme governing cellular aging

Slightly Warm | Sweet | Lung · Spleen

WHAT TCM USES IT FOR

Astragalus's signature function is strengthening **Wei Qi (defensive Qi)** — the body's invisible force field circulating at the skin and mucous membranes. When Wei Qi is weak, you catch every cold. **Critical caveat:** use it preventively or during recovery — never during an active infection with fever, as it can trap the pathogen inside.

THE THING MOST PEOPLE DON'T KNOW

Astragalus is the only traditional herb from which a compound — **cycloastragenol (TA-65)** — has been developed and clinically validated as a **telomerase activator that slows biological aging**. A root that Chinese herbalists called a "longevity tonic" for 2,000+ years has been validated at the molecular level as acting on one of the most fundamental mechanisms of aging: telomere maintenance.

WHAT SCIENCE SAYS

A 2024 randomized, double-blind, placebo-controlled trial of 40 healthy volunteers confirmed six months of astragalus supplementation **significantly lengthened both median and short telomeres**. Its polysaccharides enhance NK cell activity, macrophage function, and T-cell proliferation.

HOW TO USE IT

- → Add 5–10 dried slices to chicken soup — simmer 30+ minutes, remove before eating
- → Simmer 9–15g with goji and red dates for 20–30 min as a tonic tea
- → Honey-prepared astragalus (蜜炙黄芪) available at Chinese herb shops works deeper for Spleen/Lung

⚠ **Caution:** Never use during acute illness with fever. Stimulates the immune system — avoid in lupus, RA, MS. Major interaction with tacrolimus (reduced blood levels by ~50%). Interacts with anticoagulants and diabetes medications.

CLASSIC FORMULA

Yù Píng Fēng Sǎn (玉屏风散) — "Jade Windscreen Powder." Just three herbs. Builds the immune system for people who catch every cold, chronic allergies, and spontaneous sweating. The name imagines a precious shield.

HERB 05 / 10

灵芝

Líng Zhī · Reishi Mushroom

Once rarer than gold, reserved for emperors

Warm | Bitter | All five Yin organs

WHAT TCM USES IT FOR

Reishi is first and foremost a **Shen (spirit) calming herb** — ancient China's answer to chronic stress and insomnia. It settles an overactive mind, promotes deep sleep, reduces anxiety, and supports emotional balance. One of the few herbs that supports all Three Treasures: Jing, Qi, and Shen simultaneously.

THE THING MOST PEOPLE DON'T KNOW

> Before cultivation techniques developed in the 1970s, **only 2–3 out of every 10,000 aged trees** had Reishi growing at their base in the wild. Its extreme scarcity made it more expensive than gold and accessible only to royalty. The **Shennong Ben Cao Jing** classified it among the "superior herbs" safe for lifelong daily use. Taoist legends spoke of secret islands where sacred groves of Reishi grew.

WHAT SCIENCE SAYS

Over **400 bioactive compounds** identified, including 130+ triterpenes (anti-inflammatory, hepatoprotective) and 200+ polysaccharide β-glucans (activate macrophages, NK cells, T-cells). A 2023 RCT of 126 healthy adults confirmed statistically significant increases in T-lymphocyte populations.

HOW TO USE IT

- → Simmer 3–5g dried slices in water for 20–30 minutes
- → Add ½–1 tsp powder to coffee, hot cacao, or smoothies
- → **Best taken in the evening** — leverages sleep-promoting properties
- → Benefits build with daily use over weeks, not days

⚠ **Caution:** Stop 2 weeks before surgery (anticoagulant effect). Avoid with immunosuppressants (counteracts them). One case of fatal hepatitis with powder. Moderate interactions with at least 69 drugs including antihypertensives and diabetes medications.

CLASSIC FORMULA

Suān Zǎo Rén Tāng (酸枣仁汤) — TCM's most famous sleep formula. Reishi is added to deepen its spirit-calming capacity. Treats insomnia, palpitations, and night sweats from Liver Blood deficiency.

HERB 06 / 10

菊花

Jú Huā · Chrysanthemum Flower

The "screen fatigue" herb with a 2,000-year festival

Slightly Cold | Sweet · Bitter | Liver · Lung

WHAT TCM USES IT FOR

Chrysanthemum's most famous use is **clearing Liver heat to benefit the eyes** — for red, dry, tired, or blurry eyes and light sensitivity. In TCM, the Liver "opens to the eyes." In the modern world, this makes it essentially the **digital eye strain herb**. Also calms Liver Yang rising for dizziness, tension headaches, and hypertension.

THE THING MOST PEOPLE DON'T KNOW

> Chrysanthemum has its own national festival — the **Double Ninth Festival (重阳节)**, celebrated on the 9th day of the 9th lunar month for over 2,000 years. People drink chrysanthemum wine, eat chrysanthemum cakes, display the flowers for longevity. Also: **white chrysanthemum** is best for nourishing the eyes, while **yellow chrysanthemum** is stronger for wind-heat colds. The variety changes the medicine.

WHAT SCIENCE SAYS

Key compound **luteolin** demonstrated neuroprotective effects by suppressing microglia-mediated neuroinflammation. A 2025 study found chrysanthemum extract enhanced sleep via GABAergic modulation. Research validated luteolin's mechanisms in mitigating dry age-related macular degeneration — **providing modern basis for the ancient eye-health claim.**

HOW TO USE IT

- → Steep 5–8 dried flower heads in boiling water 3–5 min. Re-steep 2–3 times
- → Add 8–10 goji berries — classic Chinese daily eye-health combo
- → Brew strong, chill, serve over ice with rock sugar for a Chinese summer drink

⚠ **Critical:** Ragweed allergy = avoid (same plant family). Transplant patients must avoid — inhibits CYP3A4, causing toxic drug levels. Documented case: kidney transplant patient

hospitalized after drinking chrysanthemum tea.

CLASSIC FORMULA

Sāng Jú Yǐn (桑菊饮) — "Mulberry Leaf & Chrysanthemum Decoction." Combines chrysanthemum with mulberry leaf for early-stage wind-heat colds with cough and sore throat.

HERB 07 / 10

龙眼肉

Lóng Yǎn Ròu · Longan Fruit

Named "Dragon Eye" — and it's literal, not mythology

Warm | Sweet | Heart · Spleen

WHAT TCM USES IT FOR

Longan nourishes Blood and calms the mind simultaneously. It addresses the **Heart-Spleen connection**: when both are depleted from overwork, illness, or childbirth, you get insomnia, anxiety, forgetfulness, palpitations, fatigue, and pale complexion all at once. Longan replenishes both. It's a staple in Chinese **postpartum recovery traditions**.

THE THING MOST PEOPLE DON'T KNOW

> **The name is literal anatomy, not mythology.** Peel away the shell and the translucent white flesh with a black seed at the center looks uncannily like an eyeball — a dark pupil surrounded by a white iris. Despite being closely related to lychee, **longan is considered medicinally warmer and more tonifying**. Lychee is the flashier cousin; longan is the quiet medicinal powerhouse.

WHAT SCIENCE SAYS

Longan aril ameliorated cognitive impairment in Alzheimer's disease mice via the **RAS/MEK/ERK signaling pathway** — directly supporting TCM's memory-improvement claim. Longan flower extract proved more potent than glutathione as an antioxidant and protected the dopaminergic system relevant to Parkinson's research.

HOW TO USE IT

→ Simmer 8–12 dried pieces with red dates and goji for blood-building tea

→ Add to rice congee or chicken soup

→ Eat 5–10 dried pieces daily like raisins

→ Postpartum: 20g longan + 10 red dates + ginger slices in broth

⚠ **Caution:** Avoid if you run hot (red face, irritability) — can paradoxically cause insomnia and nosebleeds in excess. High natural sugar (~60–70% by weight). Not for dampness or phlegm-fire patterns.

CLASSIC FORMULA

Guī Pí Tāng (归脾汤) — "Restore the Spleen Decoction," from 1253 CE. The definitive formula for Heart-Spleen dual deficiency: fatigue, insomnia, anxiety, forgetfulness, palpitations. Longan is a principal herb.

HERB 08 / 10

山楂

Shān Zhā · Hawthorn Berry

The digestive herb that Western cardiology discovered independently

Slightly Warm | Sour · Sweet | Spleen · Stomach · Liver · Heart

WHAT TCM USES IT FOR

Hawthorn is TCM's go-to for **food stagnation** — the heavy, bloated, stuck feeling after overeating, especially from greasy meat-heavy meals. It "conquers and cuts down" accumulated food, invigorates blood circulation, and transforms lipid accumulation. A centuries-old after-dinner herb.

THE THING MOST PEOPLE DON'T KNOW

Here lies one of the most striking East-West divergences in herbal medicine. **In TCM, hawthorn is a digestive herb (used 1,400+ years for stomach complaints). In Western medicine, it's researched almost exclusively as a heart medicine.** Both

traditions are correct — the same compounds that break down fats in digestion also dilate coronary vessels, reduce cholesterol, and strengthen cardiac contractions. Hawthorn is also **the original fruit in tanghulu (冰糖葫芦)** — the iconic candied fruit skewers that went viral on TikTok.

WHAT SCIENCE SAYS

The landmark SPICE trial enrolled **2,681 heart failure patients** across 13 European countries and found standardized hawthorn extract may reduce sudden cardiac death. A meta-analysis confirmed significant improvement in exercise tolerance and cardiac function versus placebo.

HOW TO USE IT

- → Steep 9–15g dried sliced berries in hot water 10–15 min after heavy meals
- → Brew 5–6 dried slices with tangerine peel for a quick digestive tea
- → Haw flakes (山楂片) — the pink candy discs at Asian markets — mildly medicinal and delicious

⚠ **Critical:** Major interaction with digoxin, beta-blockers, and PDE5 inhibitors (sildenafil). Moderate interactions with at least 51 drugs. Stop 2 weeks before surgery. Avoid misuse without food stagnation — long-term use weakens Spleen Qi.

CLASSIC FORMULA

Bǎo Hé Wán (保和丸) — "Preserve Harmony Pill," Yuan Dynasty. TCM's comprehensive after-dinner digestive. Hawthorn as chief herb. Widely available OTC and often recommended as a travel companion.

HERB 09 / 10

五味子

Wǔ Wèi Zǐ · Schisandra Berry — "Five Flavor Seed"

A Soviet military secret and the only fruit with all five tastes

Warm | All five flavors | Lung · Kidney · Heart

WHAT TCM USES IT FOR

Schisandra is a "sealer" that **prevents the body from leaking vital energy**. It astringes the Lungs to stop chronic cough, tonifies the Kidneys for night sweats and frequent urination, generates fluids to halt excessive sweating, and calms the Heart for insomnia. Think of it as helping the body hold onto what it already has rather than adding something new.

THE THING MOST PEOPLE DON'T KNOW

> In the 1940s–60s, the **Soviet military secretly studied schisandra** as a natural performance enhancer. Classified research tested formulas on military cadets, cosmonauts, and Olympic athletes. It improved endurance, sharpened visual acuity, and enhanced mental clarity under extreme stress. **The term "adaptogen" itself was coined in 1947** to describe these stress-resistance substances — schisandra was the founding example. It remains **the only known fruit naturally containing all five fundamental tastes**.

WHAT SCIENCE SAYS

Schisandrin B reduced liver damage markers by **78%** in research models through enhanced mitochondrial glutathione status. Human RCTs confirmed improvement in skeletal muscle strength in older adults and significant reduction in menopausal hot flashes and palpitations.

HOW TO USE IT

- → Simmer 3–6g lightly crushed berries in 300ml water 15 min at gentle simmer
- → Traditional dose: 20–30 drops tincture in water, twice daily
- → Steep in raw honey 2–4 weeks for a schisandra-infused honey
- → **Avoid after 6–7 PM** — mild stimulating effects

⚠ **Critical:** Avoid in pregnancy (may stimulate uterine contractions) and epilepsy. Critical interaction with tacrolimus. Inhibits CYP3A4 and CYP1A2 — affects many common medications. May increase sedation with benzodiazepines.

CLASSIC FORMULA

Shēng Mài Sǎn (生脉散) — "Generate the Pulse Powder." Three herbs: ginseng + ophiopogon + schisandra. In modern Chinese hospitals, administered as an **IV drip for cardiovascular emergencies**. A bridge between ancient formula and ICU medicine.

HERB 10 / 10

莲子

Lián Zǐ · Lotus Seed

Seeds that germinated after 1,300 years of dormancy

Neutral | Sweet · Astringent | Heart · Spleen · Kidney

WHAT TCM USES IT FOR

Lotus seed is a gentle stabilizer that simultaneously **tonifies the Spleen** (digestion, stops chronic diarrhea), **tonifies the Kidneys** (frequent urination, nocturnal emissions), and **nourishes the Heart** (anxiety, palpitations, insomnia). Its neutral nature means it's safe for nearly all constitution types.

THE THING MOST PEOPLE DON'T KNOW

> In 1982, UCLA researchers obtained ancient lotus seeds from a dry lakebed in China. Filed through their hard shells — **they sprouted within four days.** Radiocarbon dating confirmed the oldest seed was **1,288 years old**. The secret is a protein-repair enzyme (PIMT) — the first protein-repair enzyme ever discovered — that continuously fixes age-damaged proteins over centuries. Also: the tiny green plumule inside each seed is a **separate herb in TCM** (Lián Zǐ Xīn). Leave it in to calm anxiety; remove it for purely digestive purposes. **Keeping or removing it changes the medicine entirely.**

WHAT SCIENCE SAYS

The alkaloid **neferine** (in the plumule) induced dose-dependent cell death in lung and cervical cancer cells while showing minimal toxicity to normal cells. It also protects endothelial cells from high-glucose damage — relevant for diabetic vascular disease.

HOW TO USE IT

- → Soak 15–30 seeds overnight, simmer with rice for lotus seed congee — ideal evening meal for insomnia
- → Make sweet soup (Lian Zi Tang) with rock sugar and red dates
- → Add 10–20g to chicken or vegetable soups during slow-cooking
- → **The plumule trick:** leave green sprout in for anxiety/insomnia; remove for digestion only

⚠ **Caution:** Avoid with constipation — astringent properties further bind the bowels. Avoid with abdominal distension or excess patterns. Those on cancer or cardiovascular drugs should consult a provider given neferine's cellular activity.

CLASSIC FORMULA

Qīng Xīn Lián Zǐ Yǐn (清心莲子饮) — From the Song Dynasty government pharmacopoeia (1107 CE). Treats Heart Fire blazing upward (anxiety, insomnia) while damp-heat pours downward (urinary problems) — treating seemingly unrelated symptoms as one interconnected pattern.

Quick Reference

HERB	NATURE	KEY ORGANS	CORE ACTION
🫚 Ginger	Warm	Lung, Stomach	Disperses cold, stops nausea
🔴 Goji	Neutral	Liver, Kidney	Nourishes Yin, brightens eyes
🟥 Jujube	Warm	Spleen, Heart	Tonifies Qi, harmonizes formulas
🌿 Astragalus	Slightly warm	Lung, Spleen	Strengthens immune defense
🍄 Reishi	Warm	All five Yin organs	Calms spirit, whole-body tonic
🌸 Chrysanthemum	Slightly cold	Liver, Lung	Clears heat, benefits eyes
🟡 Longan	Warm	Heart, Spleen	Nourishes blood, calms mind
🫐 Hawthorn	Slightly warm	Spleen, Heart	Dissolves food stagnation
🍒 Schisandra	Warm	Lung, Kidney, Heart	Astringes leaking energy
⚪ Lotus Seed	Neutral	Heart, Spleen, Kidney	Stabilizes, nourishes, calms

A pharmacy hiding in plain sight

The most striking pattern across these ten herbs is how consistently modern pharmacology validates specific TCM classifications that predate the scientific method by millennia. **Ginger's anti-nausea action works through the same receptor pathway as prescription Zofran.** Astragalus's "longevity tonic" reputation maps precisely onto telomerase activation. Goji's eye-health claim rests on zeaxanthin concentrations unmatched in nature.

Three practical principles to remember. **First, thermal nature matters** — warming herbs suit people who run cold; cooling herbs suit those who run hot. Using the wrong temperature can worsen symptoms. **Second, nearly every herb listed interacts with pharmaceutical drugs** — always check before combining. **Third, these herbs work through accumulation, not acute dosing.** Weeks and months of consistent daily use — not heroic single doses.

Start with the food-grade herbs: jujube, goji, longan, lotus seed. Add them to cooking. See what changes.

@dailyherbchinese · One herb. Every day.